than suffer the constant humiliation.

Following the Lok Sabha debacle, the NCP has also become the Mahayuti's weakest link. At the recent INDIA TODAY conclave in Mumbai, BJP leader and fellow deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis said the NCP's votes had not transferred to the BJP in expected numbers in the Lok Sabha election. But despite being in a bad marriage, the allies have no choice but to continue. As a senior BJP MLA says, "The alliance is hurting us, but we cannot afford to snap ties with him as it will create a perception of our being selfish."

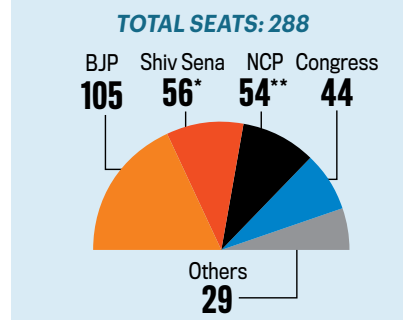
A LITMUS TEST FOR AJIT

Not only has his own allies lost confidence in Ajit's ability to deliver electorally, even the Opposition camp thinks he is a spent force. According to a former Congress minister, the perception that Ajit crossed over to the BJP side to escape investigation by the central investigation agencies has dented his image drastically. Further, as a senior bureaucrat notes, while the battle for the 'real' Shiv Sena between Chief Minister Eknath Shinde and Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray remains undecided, Pawar Senior seems to have defeated his nephew Ajit decisively in the claim over the real NCP. If rumours are to be believed, a few NCP MLAs, who last year had sided with Ajit 'Dada', may be having second thoughts now. Former minister Dr Rajendra Shingne has admitted that he sided with Ajit only to ensure financial aid for the Buldhana district co-operative bank. Earlier, Nilesh Lanke and Bajrang Sonwane had also returned to Sharad Pawar's NCP and are the party's current MPs from Ahmednagar and Beed, respectively. A few BJP leaders, from former minister Harshavardhan Patil, Samarjeetsinh Ghatge of the Kagal royal family to ex-MLA Bapusaheb Pathare from Vadgaon Sheri have also joined Sharad Pawar's NCP or NCP(SP).

The wider Pawar clan, meanwhile, is firmly on the patriarch's side, evident in their support during the general election. It translated into NCP(SP) bagging family pocket borough Baramati, dealing a blow to Ajit's influence in the region and handing defeat to wife Sunetra at the hands of Supriya Sule.

Given these circumstances, Ajit has hinted that he may stay away from Baramati, a seat he has represented since 1991. There is a possibility that his younger son Jay may be fielded from there, with Ajit fighting from Shirur in Pune. Some others say he may keep away from the electoral contest altogether and campaign for the party instead. Ajit himself has kept his cards close to his chest, willing only to say that the decision will be taken by the NCP's parliamentary board (see interview, *'CM will be chosen after election'*).

MANDATE MATH
Party position in 2019 Maharashtra assembly polls



**Undivided, 38 MLAs are with Shinde-led Shiv Sena; ** Undivided, Ajit's NCP claims support of over 40 MLAs*

NCP(SP) itself may pick Yugendra, son of Ajit's younger brother Shrinivas, or Rajendra, son of Sharad Pawar's elder brother Dinkarrao aka Appasaheb, for the Baramati battle, which promises to go down to the wire. An NCP(SP) source, however, is convinced that Ajit is likely to backtrack after "pressure from his workers" and contest from Baramati.

UNEASE OVER HINDUTVA

The BJP, meanwhile, is set on trying to consolidate its workers and core voters through Hindutva, with party MLA Nitesh Rane leading the charge with his dog-whistling statements against the Muslims. While the BJP and the undivided Sena were seen as the flag-bearers of aggressive Hindutva till the Uddhav faction diluted its ideology to become part of the MVA, Rane's statements have upset the NCP, which gets a section of the Muslim vote and is planning to field Muslim faces such as Hasan Mushrif, Zeeshan Siddique, Sana Malik-Shaikh and Nawab Malik for the state polls.

A senior NCP leader has, in fact, pointed out that the Lok Sabha election had revealed how Muslims and other minorities had consolidated in favour of the MVA due to the BJP's shrill rhetoric, and this may repeat itself in the assembly election. At an event in Buldhana, where Shinde and Fadnavis, too, were present, Ajit called on "*vachalveers*" (motormouths) to observe restraint. Senior NCP leaders have said that they have communicated their reservations to the BJP high command.

According to journalist Vijay Chormare, Ajit is trying to show that his party has an agenda separate from the BJP's. "He visited Pusesavali in Satara and Vishalgad in Kolhapur after the communal riots and held meetings regarding quotas for Muslims. This is an attempt to show that he is with the BJP only for development and sans any ideological compromises." But it's a double-edged sword. As a senior BJP source puts it: "For the average NCP voter, Ajit has militated against his ideology by joining the BJP." Within the Mahayuti, however, he is ploughing a lone ideological furrow, says a Shiv Sena source. "He is seen as resisting Hindutva, which is affecting the transfer of the BJP's votes to him."

For the moment, though, the NCP is focusing on taking the government's welfare schemes to the masses with the tagline 'Dadacha Vaada' (Dada's promise). "Ajit Dada is being projected as the architect of these schemes and someone who can deliver. This may yield political dividends for us," says an NCP functionary. Ajit also has leaders with a strong constituency base, which may also stand him in good stead.

Not everyone is sure. Journalist Abhay Deshpande believes legislators may change loyalties to be close to the centre of power. "Some MLAs are likely to take a different position on the eve of the polls," he notes. Ajit could also find its position eroded further after the positive election results in Haryana, bolstering the BJP's confidence and making it less reliant on allies. ■